

BETTER VICE CLUB

Learn.WitUS Curriculum

CentenarianOS Academy

Episode 1

Coffee

"The Morning Ritual"

Geography

Teacher Curriculum Packet

High School Pilot | 2025-2026

How Better Vice Club Works

Better Vice Club (BVC) is a podcast curriculum that teaches Geography, Social Studies, Economics, and English Language Arts through global commodities. Each episode follows a single substance from its geographic origin through its history, economics, and the literature it generated. Your packet isolates your subject so you can use it standalone, or coordinate with other departments for a full interdisciplinary unit.

What You Need

- Episode audio linked on the Episode Overview page. Episodes run 35 to 40 minutes. You can use the full episode or specific segments called CUT POINTS.
- This packet. All student-facing materials are here, ready to print or share digitally.
- No additional materials required for the core activities.

CUT POINTS

Each episode is divided into labeled segments. You do not need to play the full episode. CUT-1D is the Economics segment; CUT-1E is ELA, and so on. Start times are on the Episode Overview page.

The Four BVC Patterns

These four patterns repeat across all three seasons of BVC, covering 21 episodes. Each subject connects to the patterns most relevant to that discipline:

- **Geography Insists.** The physical landscape determines what can grow and how it tastes.
- **Cultivation Begins Sacred.** Most commodities begin as ceremonial practice before they become commercial products.
- **Labor Captures the Smallest Share.** Producers earn the least. Brands and retailers earn the most.

- What Gets Burned, What Gets Saved. Who controls the narrative about a commodity shapes its history.

BVC is produced by Anthony McDonald in Indianapolis, Indiana. All content is documented with peer-reviewed APA citations. No fabricated stories or unnamed expert characters appear in any episode. The curriculum brand is Learn.WitUS, hosted at CentenarianOS.com/academy.

Episode 1 Overview: Coffee

Detail	Information
Episode title	The Morning Ritual
Season	Season 1: Daily Rituals
Full runtime	35 to 40 minutes
Subjects	Geography, Social Studies, Economics, ELA (all four in one episode)
Audio access	CentenarianOS.com/academy or ask your BVC contact for the file
Recommended grade	9 to 12 (Indiana Academic Standards aligned)

Segment Map

Use CUT POINTS to navigate directly to your subject without playing the full episode.

Cut ID	Segment Title	Start Time	Duration	Subject
CUT-1A	Cold Open: A Cup of Questions	0:00	2 min	All subjects
CUT-1B	The Bean Belt	2:00	8 min	Geography
CUT-1C	From Ethiopia to Empire	10:00	8 min	Social Studies
CUT-1D	What's in Your Cup?	18:00	8 min	Economics
CUT-1E	Stories in Every Cup	26:00	8 min	ELA
CUT-1F	The Conscious Cup (Closing)	34:00	2 min	All subjects

Episode Summary

Episode 1 follows coffee from the volcanic highlands of Ethiopia through the colonial trade routes that spread it globally, to the supply chain economics that determine who earns what from the world's second-largest commodity market. Anthony McDonald opens with his morning routine in Indianapolis and traces the cup in his hand back through geography, history, economics, and literature.

Cross-curricular note: If colleagues in other departments are also piloting BVC, their students are studying the same episode through different lenses. The Season 2 finale (Episode 14) includes a cross-subject Pattern Wall activity that explicitly connects all four disciplines.

Geography Vocabulary

Introduce these terms before playing the Geography segment (CUT-1B, starting at 2:00).

Term	Pronunciation	Definition
Coffee Belt	KAW-fee BELT	The band between 25 degrees N and 30 degrees S latitude where coffee grows commercially. Also called the Bean Belt.
Arabica	ah-RAB-ih-kah	The higher-quality coffee species, accounting for 70 percent of global production. Requires elevation of 800 to 2,000 meters.
Robusta	roh-BUS-tah	The second major coffee species. Hardier and more bitter than Arabica, grown at lower elevations.
Terroir	tehr-WAHR	The combination of soil, climate, and geography that gives a product its distinctive character.
Elevation	el-eh-VAY-shun	Height above sea level. Higher elevation produces cooler temperatures, slower ripening, and more complex flavor.
Supply chain	SUH-ply CHAYN	The full sequence of steps a commodity travels: farming, processing, shipping, roasting, and retail.
Commodity	kuh-MOD-ih-tee	A raw material or agricultural product traded in large quantities on global markets.

Monoculture	MON-oh-kul-cher	Growing only one crop on a large area. Increases yield but reduces biodiversity and climate resilience.
Fair Trade	FAIR TRAYD	A certification system guaranteeing minimum prices and better working conditions for small-scale producers.
Climate migration	KLY-met my-GRAY-shun	When changing temperatures force crops to move to higher elevations or different regions over time.

Geography Data Sheet: The Coffee Belt

Climate Requirements for Arabica Coffee

Factor	Arabica Requirement	Why It Matters
Temperature	15 to 24 degrees C (60 to 70 F)	Temperatures above 30 degrees C cause plant damage. Frost kills plants instantly.
Annual rainfall	1,500 to 2,000 mm	Too little rain causes drought stress. Too much leads to root disease.
Elevation	800 to 2,000 meters above sea level	Higher altitude means slower ripening, which builds more complex flavor compounds.
Dry period	2 to 3 months annually	Required for coffee cherries to ripen properly before harvest.
Soil pH	5.5 to 6.5 (slightly acidic)	Alkaline soils reduce the plant's ability to absorb nutrients.
Frost tolerance	None. Zero degrees C kills plants.	Limits commercial production to frost-free latitudes within the Coffee Belt.

Top 10 Coffee-Producing Countries (2024)

Rank	Country	Annual Production (tonnes)	Pct of Global Total	Primary Type
1	Brazil	2,600,000 to 3,800,000	38%	Arabica + Robusta
2	Vietnam	1,540,000 to 1,960,000	18%	Robusta
3	Colombia	760,000	8%	100% Arabica

4	Indonesia	668,000	7%	Robusta + Arabica
5	Ethiopia	421,000	4%	Arabica (origin country)
6	Honduras	475,000	5%	Arabica
7	Peru	346,000	3%	Arabica (organic)
8	India	234,000 to 312,000	3%	Mixed
9	Uganda	209,000	2%	80% Robusta
10	Mexico	240,000	2%	Arabica

Climate Change: Elevation Shifts Projected to 2050

Region	Minimum Altitude Today	Minimum Altitude (2050 projected)	Suitable Land Change
Central America	600 m	1,000 m	Up to 89% loss
Kenya	1,000 m	1,400 m	Significant loss
Brazil (Sao Paulo state)	400 m	700 m	25 to 40% loss
Ethiopia	1,400 m	1,800 m	Up to 60% loss

Indiana connection: Indiana sits at approximately 40 degrees N latitude, well outside the Coffee Belt. Average Indiana winter temperatures fall below zero degrees C, which is fatal to coffee plants. No commercial coffee production is geographically possible in Indiana. Your morning cup began at least 7,000 miles from Indianapolis.

Geography Activity: Coffee Belt Explorer

Time: 30 to 40 minutes. Materials: this packet plus a world map or Google Earth.

Step 1: Map the Coffee Belt (10 minutes)

On a world map, draw lines at 25 degrees N and 30 degrees S latitude. This band is the Coffee Belt. Then:

- Shade or mark the top five producing countries from the data sheet.
- Mark Indianapolis, Indiana (39.8 degrees N, outside the belt).
- Label the Coffee Belt boundaries with their degree values.

Step 2: Climate Analysis (10 minutes)

Students use the climate requirements table to answer these questions:

- Why can coffee not grow in Indiana? List three specific climate reasons with data.
- Ethiopia ranks 5th in volume but is coffee's origin country. Colombia ranks 3rd. Using the climate data, explain why Colombia's geography produces higher-quality beans despite lower volume than Brazil.
- Vietnam grows 18 percent of global coffee at lower elevations than Colombia. What variety does Vietnam primarily grow, and what trade-off does this represent for flavor versus volume?

Step 3: Supply Chain Route (10 minutes)

Trace one coffee supply chain from origin to Indianapolis. Choose either Ethiopia (Yirgacheffe: 6.1 degrees N, 38.2 degrees E) or Colombia (Huila: 2 degrees N, 76 degrees W). Then:

- Draw the shipping route from origin to the nearest major port, then to a U.S. port of entry, then to Indianapolis.
- Estimate total distance in kilometers.
- Identify one geographic challenge the coffee faces on its journey (monsoon season, mountain crossing, or long ocean route).

Discussion Questions

- Brazil and Vietnam together produce 55 percent of the world's coffee. What happens to global supply when Brazil has a severe drought or frost season?
- Suitable coffee land is shrinking by up to 89 percent in some regions by 2050. What adaptation options do farmers have, and what geographic limits do those options have?

Geography Knowledge Checks

Use as an exit ticket, short quiz, or discussion prompt. Answer key follows.

1. Define the Coffee Belt and explain why coffee cannot be grown commercially in Indiana. Use at least two specific climate factors with data from the data sheet.
2. Colombia grows 100 percent Arabica coffee at elevations of 1,200 to 2,000 meters. Brazil also grows Arabica but at lower elevations and in far greater quantities. Using the climate data, explain why Colombian coffee is generally considered higher quality, and why Brazil still dominates global production volume.
3. Climate change is projected to reduce suitable coffee-growing land by up to 89 percent in Central America by 2050. Using geographic reasoning: (a) why is this happening, (b) what adaptation options do farmers have, and (c) what are the limits of those adaptations?

Answer Key (teacher reference only)

Q1 expected answer:

Coffee Belt runs from 25 degrees N to 30 degrees S. Indiana is at roughly 40 degrees N, outside the belt. Required climate reasons include: (1) Indiana winter temperatures fall below zero degrees C and coffee plants have zero frost tolerance; (2) Indiana annual rainfall of approximately 1,100 mm falls below the 1,500 to 2,000 mm Arabica minimum; and (3) Indiana summer temperatures regularly exceed the 30 degree C plant-damage threshold. Any two with specific data from the sheet are acceptable.

Q2 expected answer:

At 1,200 to 2,000 meters, Colombian farms experience cooler temperatures and slower fruit ripening, allowing more complex flavor compounds to develop. Brazil's lower-elevation farms accelerate ripening but reduce complexity. Brazil wins volume through vast suitable land area and mechanical harvesting. Colombia wins quality because its geography forces slower development. Students should cite specific elevation and temperature figures.

Q3 expected answer:

(a) Rising temperatures push minimum viable elevation higher. Farms currently viable at 600 meters become too warm. (b) Adaptation options include moving farms to higher elevation, planting shade trees to buffer temperature, and switching to heat-resistant varieties. (c) Limits: there is a ceiling on available altitude in any mountain range; shade trees take years to establish; resistant varieties may sacrifice quality; in densely populated highlands, higher land may not be available or affordable.

Indiana Geography Standards Alignment

Standard	Description	Where Addressed in This Packet
WG.1.1	Use geographic tools to analyze spatial patterns	Coffee Belt mapping activity; supply chain route tracing
WG.1.3	Analyze distributions using geographic data	Top 10 producers table; regional production percentages
WG.3.1	Analyze characteristics of climate zones	Climate requirements table; Coffee Belt definition and limits
WG.3.2	Evaluate how physical systems affect human activity	Climate conditions determining crop viability; geography shaping supply chain cost
WG.5.1	Analyze how human activity modifies the physical environment	Monoculture impacts; deforestation for coffee expansion
WG.5.3	Evaluate consequences of human-environment interaction	Climate change reducing suitable land; adaptation options and limits

Reviewer's Feedback Form

Your feedback directly shapes the Learn.WitUS curriculum. Please complete this form after using the materials with students.

DIGITAL VERSION: Scan the QR code below or visit the link provided by your BVC contact. Responses feed directly into a shared spreadsheet for curriculum improvement.

[QR CODE]

About You

1. Subject you teach:

2. Grade level(s) in this pilot:

3. Approximate number of students who used this material:

About the Materials

4. Which segment(s) or activities did you use?

5. Did students have sufficient background knowledge to engage? What was missing or helpful?

6. Were the Indiana Standards alignments accurate for how you teach this standard?

Student Engagement

7. Scale 1 to 5: How well did the episode hold student attention? (1 = struggled, 5 = highly engaged) Notes:

8. What specific activity or discussion moment generated the most student response?

Usability

9. Would you use this as a standalone lesson, a unit anchor, or a recurring series? Why?

10. The single change that would make this most usable in your classroom next fall:

Overall

11. Would you recommend this curriculum to a colleague? What would you say?

Responses are confidential and used only to improve Learn.WitUS curriculum. Thank you for your time and expertise. Anthony McDonald, Better Vice Club